me in deep shit. Once or twice up to chin level, and, let me tell you, it doesn't smell great. These are the kinds of things the tabloid media thrive on.

However, the flip side is that I've also had an unbelievable amount of fun, met some incredible people, had the pleasure of knowing many beautiful women, played some explosive innings and scored many runs. I won't give you the juice now, but keep reading and the following chapters get interesting, I promise.

I think my attitude to money is a pretty good reflection of my personality. It not only illustrates my general balls-to-the-wall approach to it all, but shows up the negative side of it too. Once I started earning money as a professional cricketer, I tended to spend it as fast as I made it. There wasn't too much in the way of forward financial planning, which was pretty indicative of my general attitude to life. In later years I learnt to curb my spending habits and, thanks to the valuable advice of people like my manager, Donné Commins, I've made some wise investments – particularly in property.

I'm still Herschelle, though, which means that there are still the occasional ill-advised little spending sprees. I do appreciate the finer things in life, and I have been very fortunate to have been able to afford some of them. So, thanks to my personality, I have definitely made some … let's call them 'rash' … decisions when it comes to money, but it's also allowed me to enjoy my life – one thing I have been equally determined to do.

When I first started playing cricket for Western Province over 20 years ago, I was still living with my parents. I was still a teenager and had no real money of my own. Almost all the cash I earned from my Province contract – about R3 000 a month, I think – went straight to my dad. He probably gave me about R500 or a little more for spending money.

He was like: 'You live under my roof and now you're earning money. You've got to pay rent, you know.' I hardly had any bladdy money in those days. I remember saving up to buy a R120 striped shirt that I absolutely had to have. The problem was, I really liked the expensive stuff – clothes, cars, girls. Which is probably why, once I did get my hands on some real money, I would spend it like there was no tomorrow. Initially, anyway.

Money has given me a lot of pleasure, but it has also financed some excesses. I earned my first fairly decent income in 1996, when I signed a contract with the United Cricket Board of South Africa (UCB) to become a